

The Khilafat and Non-Cooperation Movement (1919–1924)

Background and Objectives

The Rowlatt Act of 1919, which allowed detention without trial, and the Jallianwala Bagh Massacre, where British troops killed hundreds of unarmed protesters, sparked outrage across India. These events, combined with the British dismemberment of the Ottoman Empire, angered Indian Muslims. They viewed the weakening of the Ottoman Sultan, their Khalifa, as an attack on the religious and political authority of Sunni Muslims.

The Khilafat Movement was launched to restore the authority of the Ottoman Sultan, prevent the disintegration of the Ottoman Empire, and unite Muslims politically. It also aimed to build Hindu-Muslim unity to resist British domination. Leaders like Shaukat Ali and Muhammad Ali (Ali Brothers) spearheaded the movement, alongside Gandhi, who supported the Khilafat cause to enlist Muslim support for the freedom struggle.

Strategies and Features

At the Nagpur Congress Session (1920), Gandhi combined the Khilafat demands with the Indian struggle for Swaraj (self-rule), leading to the adoption of the Non-Cooperation Movement.

- **Boycotts:** Indians were urged to boycott British educational institutions, courts, and goods, including foreign cloth.
- **National Institutions:** Efforts were made to establish alternative institutions to promote self-reliance.

End of the Non-Cooperation Movement

The movement witnessed widespread participation but faced challenges. The Chauri Chaura incident (1922), where a violent mob set a police station on fire, killing 22 policemen, forced Gandhi to call off the movement. While the Khilafat Movement eventually lost momentum following the abolition of the Ottoman Caliphate in 1924, it laid the groundwork for future Hindu-Muslim collaboration in the national struggle.

Hindu-Muslim Unity: The Bengal Pact (1923)

Efforts to strengthen Hindu-Muslim unity continued with initiatives like the Bengal Pact (1923). Proposed by C.R. Das, the pact aimed to address communal tensions in Bengal by

ensuring fair representation in jobs, education, and legislative seats based on religious population.

Key Features of the Bengal Pact:

- Electoral Representation: 60% of seats reserved for Muslims and 40% for Hindus in institutions.
- Job Reservations: 55% of government jobs reserved for Muslims, with 80% of new appointments allocated to Muslims until the quota was met.
- Cultural Sensitivities: Measures like restrictions on music near mosques during prayers and non-interference with cow slaughter for religious sacrifices were introduced to respect religious sentiments.

Although the Bengal Provincial Congress Committee accepted the pact, it faced resistance from other quarters, limiting its impact.

The Salt March and Round Table Conferences

The Salt March (1930)

Gandhi launched the Salt Satyagraha to protest the British Salt Act, which forbade Indians from collecting or selling salt, forcing them to purchase heavily taxed salt from the British. The Salt March symbolized mass resistance, with thousands of Indians joining Gandhi in defiance of colonial laws.

Round Table Conferences (1931–1932)

The British held three Round Table Conferences in London to discuss India's constitutional future. The discussions led to the formulation of the Government of India Act (1935), which introduced provincial autonomy and limited self-rule.

The Government of India Act, 1935

The Government of India Act, 1935 was a landmark legislation that marked a significant step toward self-governance.

Key Features of the Act:

- Provincial Autonomy: Allowed provinces to elect their own governments and exercise greater administrative control.
- All-India Federation: Proposed a federation of British territories and princely states, though it was never fully implemented.
- Universal Adult Franchise: Voting rights were extended to all adult citizens.
- Minority Safeguards: Communal electorates and protective measures for minorities were retained.

The act's provisions enabled the first general elections in 1937, where regional parties like the Krishak-Praja Party emerged as significant players.

The Krishak-Praja Party (KPP)

Origins and Objectives

The Krishak-Praja Party (KPP) emerged in Bengal as a voice for peasants and rural communities, addressing issues neglected by the Congress and the Muslim League. Founded by A.K. Fazlul Huq, the KPP advocated for the rights of tenants and smallholders.

Demands of the KPP:

- Abolition of the Zamindari System: Ensuring peasants' absolute proprietorship of land.
- Reduction in Land Rent Rates and interest-free loans for farmers.
- Infrastructure Development: Irrigation facilities and canals to improve agriculture.
- Free Primary Education: Universal access to education for rural communities.

1937 Bengal Legislative Assembly Elections

In the 1937 elections, the KPP campaigned on a manifesto of "Dal-Bhat (Rice and Lentils) for All."

- Election Results: The KPP won 36 seats (33 from Bengal), Congress secured 52, and the Muslim League 39.
- Coalition Government: The KPP formed a coalition government with the Muslim League, highlighting its growing influence among Bengal's rural electorate.

Conclusion

The Khilafat and Non-Cooperation Movements, the Bengal Pact, and the emergence of the Krishak-Praja Party represent significant milestones in India's struggle for independence. Each movement reflected the unique socio-political dynamics of the time, from communal unity to the rise of peasant politics. These events not only shaped the broader nationalist movement but also laid the foundation for India's eventual independence in 1947.

The Lahore Resolution and the Two-Nation Theory

The Lahore Resolution was adopted during the All India Muslim League's conference on March 22–24, 1940, in Lahore. It emphasized the need for "independent and sovereign states" for Muslims in the northwestern and eastern zones of India. The resolution was underpinned by the Two-Nation Theory, which argued that Hindus and Muslims were distinct nations with unique cultural, religious, and political aspirations.

This resolution laid the foundation for the creation of Pakistan, providing a political framework that emphasized the protection of Muslim rights in a predominantly Hindu India. Leaders like Muhammad Ali Jinnah championed this vision, which ultimately culminated in the partition of India in 1947.

Cripps Mission and the Quit India Movement

In April 1942, the Cripps Mission was sent to India by the British government to secure Indian support for the Allied war effort during World War II. Sir Stafford Cripps offered promises of elections, dominion status, and the establishment of a Constituent Assembly after the war. However, the proposal lacked substance, as it deferred key issues like independence.

The Indian National Congress rejected the mission's proposals, leading to the Quit India Movement, launched by Mahatma Gandhi in August 1942. Gandhi called for immediate and complete independence, urging Indians to adopt the slogan, "Do or Die." The movement saw widespread civil disobedience, protests, and strikes. The British responded with mass arrests, detaining Gandhi, Nehru, and other leaders, while over 100,000 individuals were imprisoned.

Although the movement was brutally suppressed, it galvanized nationalist sentiment and made it clear that the British would have to leave India eventually.

Gandhi's Ideology vs. Subhas Chandra Bose's Approach

Mahatma Gandhi's political philosophy revolved around non-violence (ahimsa) and civil disobedience (satyagraha). He combined the Non-Cooperation Movement with the Khilafat Movement, seeking Hindu-Muslim unity against British rule. Gandhi promoted the use of swadeshi goods, such as khadi, to encourage self-reliance.

However, Gandhi's approach faced criticism for its inconsistencies. For instance, he condoned British violence in certain contexts while preaching non-violence to Indians.

In contrast, Subhas Chandra Bose believed in a more militant approach to achieving independence. Bose resigned from Congress in 1939 due to differences with Gandhi and founded the Forward Bloc. During World War II, he allied with Axis powers and revived the Indian National Army (INA), which fought alongside Japan against British forces. Bose's famous slogan, "Give me blood, and I shall give you freedom," symbolized his belief in achieving liberation through armed struggle.

Post-War Developments and the Cabinet Mission

World War II left Britain economically drained and unable to suppress growing demands for independence. The Cabinet Mission of 1946 sought to transfer power to Indian leadership while maintaining a united India. The mission proposed a three-tier federal structure with a weak central government and strong provincial autonomy.

While both the Congress and the Muslim League initially accepted the proposal, differences soon emerged. The Congress preferred a strong central government, while the Muslim League demanded safeguards for Muslim rights. The failure of the Cabinet Mission ultimately paved the way for Partition.

Partition and the Radcliffe Boundary Commission

The Partition of India in 1947 was one of the most significant and traumatic events in South Asian history. The Radcliffe Boundary Commission, led by Sir Cyril Radcliffe, was tasked with drawing the borders between India and Pakistan. With no prior knowledge of Indian geography or culture, Radcliffe completed the task in just five weeks.

The resulting division led to massive communal violence, with over one million people killed and 15 million displaced. Cities like Punjab and Bengal became epicenters of riots, while the forced migration of Hindus, Muslims, and Sikhs left deep scars on the region's socio-political fabric.

Cultural and Linguistic Divides in Pakistan

Following Partition, significant differences emerged between East and West Pakistan. East Pakistan had a majority population, with over 54% speaking Bangla, while Urdu was spoken by only 7% of the population, primarily in West Pakistan. Despite this, Urdu was declared the sole state language of Pakistan, disregarding the linguistic and cultural identity of East Pakistanis.

The imposition of Urdu sparked the Language Movement, beginning with protests by students and intellectuals. On February 21, 1952, police opened fire on demonstrators in Dhaka, killing several protesters. This day became a symbol of Bengali nationalism and is now observed as International Mother Language Day.

Economic Exploitation of East Pakistan

East Pakistan generated the bulk of Pakistan's export revenue, primarily through its jute industry, yet it received minimal investments. Non-Bengalis controlled 62% of state loans in East Pakistan, 93% of large imports, and most trade. This economic disparity bred resentment and calls for autonomy.

Bengali economists like Rehman Sobhan and Nurul Islam highlighted the structural inequalities, advocating for regional economic autonomy.

Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and the Six-Point Demand

The frustration of East Pakistanis culminated in Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's Six-Point Demand, presented in 1966 as a blueprint for autonomy. These were:

1. A federal structure with a parliamentary system directly elected by universal adult franchise.
2. The central government's authority limited to defense and foreign affairs.
3. Two separate, freely convertible currencies or economic safeguards to prevent capital flight from East Pakistan.
4. Provincial control over taxation and revenue collection, with the federal government receiving a share.
5. Separate accounts for foreign exchange earnings in each province.
6. The establishment of a regional militia for East Pakistan.

These demands became the manifesto for Bengali autonomy and were met with strong opposition from West Pakistani leaders.

The 1970 Election and the Liberation War

The 1970 general election was a decisive moment. The Awami League, led by Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, won 160 of 162 seats in East Pakistan, securing a majority in Pakistan's parliament. However, West Pakistani leaders, including Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, refused to cede power.

The crisis escalated into military action, with Operation Searchlight launched on March 25, 1971. The operation targeted Dhaka University, Hindu neighborhoods, and civilian populations, resulting in widespread atrocities.

On March 26, 1971, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman declared Bangladesh's independence. The Mukti Bahini (freedom fighters) launched guerrilla warfare against the Pakistani military, with significant support from India. The Indo-Pak war in December 1971 culminated in Pakistan's surrender on December 16, 1971, marking the birth of Bangladesh.

Legacy of the Liberation War

The Liberation War of 1971 was a culmination of decades of linguistic, cultural, and economic struggles. The Language Movement and the Six-Point Demand were pivotal in uniting East Pakistanis under the banner of Bengali nationalism.

Bangladesh's independence underscored the limitations of religious nationalism as a unifying force, highlighting the importance of linguistic and cultural identity. The recognition of February 21 as International Mother Language Day by UNESCO symbolizes this struggle.

Conclusion

The history of South Asia's struggle for independence reflects the resilience of its people in overcoming political, cultural, and economic oppression. From the Two-Nation Theory to the Liberation War, each movement and demand contributed to the eventual creation of independent nations. The sacrifices of the Bengali people, particularly through the Language Movement and the Six-Point Demand, serve as a lasting testament to the power of cultural identity and self-determination.